



Disability Justice: The Challenges of Inclusion in Everyday Life

Julie- Mary Carmel, Sian Chapman & Peter Wright

To cite this article: Julie- Mary Carmel, Sian Chapman & Peter Wright (2026) Disability Justice: The Challenges of Inclusion in Everyday Life, International Journal of Disability, Development and Education, 73:4, 621-634, DOI: [10.1080/1034912X.2025.2456288](https://doi.org/10.1080/1034912X.2025.2456288)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/1034912X.2025.2456288>



© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group.



Published online: 27 Jan 2025.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 5146



View related articles [↗](#)



View Crossmark data [↗](#)



Citing articles: 5 View citing articles [↗](#)



OPEN ACCESS



Disability Justice: The Challenges of Inclusion in Everyday Life

Julie- Mary Carmel , Sian Chapman  and Peter Wright 

Murdoch University, Perth, Western Australia

ABSTRACT

This paper presents the challenges faced by Taylor (pseudonym), a young child, with a disability navigating everyday life. These challenges reflect issues that many people with disabilities face where Diversity, Inclusion and Equity are key to **disability justice**. Highlighting places and spaces of inclusion and exclusion in both formal and non-formal settings, we describe sites where Taylor is both constrained and enabled and consider what that might mean. Informed by the first author's carer position, eight vignettes provide both context and consideration, making these challenges visible and hence provocations for change. These accounts are considered in relation to key concepts of the social model of disability within a critical disability framework. This exploration highlights how society's perceptions are largely bound by a bio-medical view of disability that promotes deficit views. By way of contrast, and beyond an impoverished framing, a social model of disability sees Taylor as a vibrant, intelligent young person seeking to live a life rich with meaning and value. What the research reveals is that learning and change are possible in both formal and non-formal settings where an enhanced understanding of places and spaces for engagement and participation means that society becomes more equitable and just.

ARTICLE HISTORY

Received 1 June 2022

Accepted 12 January 2025

KEYWORDS

Autoethnographic; critical disability theory; disability justice; diversity; equity; inclusion

I wish people could see me first and what I can do instead of seeing me in a wheelchair first.
Taylor (2018) 'personal conversation'.

Taylor [pseudonym] is a vibrant, intelligent, funny personable child who was between 3 and 6 years of age during this investigation. Consistent with others the same age, Taylor loves venturing out into the community, going to live theatre and musicals, eating in restaurants, and visiting anywhere there are animals. Taylor has a physical disability that requires the use of a wheelchair to participate in these activities. While in many contexts, the use of this mobility device would seem to be limiting, when talking about having a disability, Taylor commented that being in a wheelchair was good because *'it made me special and it was fun'* (Taylor, 2016).

For some, Taylor's comments and perspective could be unsettling or defiant because it challenges society's perception of disability by contradicting previous calls for people with a disability (PWD) to covet normalness (Barnes & Mercer, 2010; Thomas & Sakellariou, 2018). In this context, being non-disabled is positioned as the a priori position of society

CONTACT Julie- Mary Carmel  julie.carmel@murdoch.edu.au

© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group.

This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivatives License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/4.0/>), which permits non-commercial re-use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, and is not altered, transformed, or built upon in any way. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

and places emphasis on society's attitude towards disability, that is an ableist attitude, rather than on disability itself (S. M. Campbell & Stramondo, 2023). What follows is a retrospective auto-ethnographic account that explores how the critical issues of *diversity, inclusion, and equity* have impacted Taylor and the first author (hereafter referred to as I), navigating their everyday world.

Theories of Disability

Interpretations of disability have been evolving in social research with an emphasis on how disability is framed within society. These interpretations have led to the development of Critical Disability Theory (CDT), with its origins coming from the Frankfurt School as an attempt to 'explain what is wrong in current social reality' (Sztobryn-Giercuskiewicz, 2017, p. 3). This critical perspective has led to a debate between what has been described as the medical/impairment model and the social model with each perspective demystifying disability and attempting to bring about social change (Sztobryn-Giercuskiewicz, 2017).

Critical Disability Theory

This is me, and I like being me. (Taylor 2018)

The task of critical disability theory (CDT) is to analyse disability in relation to cultural, historical, relative, social, and political phenomenon (Hall, 2019). Traditionally, the study of disability has intersected with other marginalised social issues such as feminism, culture, and queer theory (Erevelles, 2011). Over the last decade 'social theories of difference have sought to denaturalize and historicize the constructions of categories' (Erevelles, 2011, p. 30) at the expense of disability. However, Goodley et al. (2012) argue that 'disability theory has not had the sweep and global interest of other areas due to the stigma that disability still carries, despite years of legislation and struggle' (p. 1).

The value of CDT lies in the way it challenges society's attitudes and assumptions that differences, such as physical and mental capacity, can be ignored and confronts these issues giving people with disabilities a voice. CDT's underlying premise is that the places and spaces where society feels the most uncomfortable are where most learning occurs, these possibilities are highlighted in this study. This possibility of learning occurs because CDT as an approach challenges society's attitudes that can be unsettling for many. For example, it has previously been the case that people with disabilities have been socially classified as outsiders, excluded from mainstream society, with little to no rights (Dixon et al., 2022; Dunn, 2019).

Research that embodies CDT provides an emancipatory and developing discourse that challenges long-held beliefs and practices concerning disability (Goodley et al., 2018; Meekosha & Shuttleworth, 2017). CDT notes the difficulties and challenges that are inherent when living with a disability, highlighting the aspiration that (PWD) be considered by society as more than their disability, and asking society to view PWD as being multifaceted, efficient and productive persons with rights as equal citizens (Munn, 2017; Pothier & Devlin, 2014). The medical/impairment model of disability

Prior to the introduction of the social model of disability, the medical/impairment model was well established as a framing device, where 'society saw disability as a 'disease that had to be diagnosed, cured, and treated' (Petasis, 2019, p. 1). Implicit in this language was an attempt to bring the 'individual as close to normalcy as possible' through medical intervention (Erevelles, 2011, p. 19). Viewing disability through this medical perspective led to stereotypical views of PWD, particularly in relation to what PWD can and cannot, should and should not do, and their place in society. This form of language, and the medical model in particular, has led to stigmatising disability as a deficit, which in turn impacts societal exclusion through accessibility, policies, and practices (Sztobryn-Giercuskiewicz, 2017) the concept being discussed in this paper.

The Social Model of Disability

By way of contrast, the social model of CDT sees disability being part of the person, and it is society that disables through its actions, attitudes, and policies more than the disability itself. In this alternate view, attention is shifted from the individual and their deficits to how society includes or excludes them (Shakespeare, 2013). Further, it draws attention to the cultural processes that shape disability where exclusion and marginalisation in society are obstacles to be overcome to provide a more inclusive society. This means in education, for example, the social model requires consideration of what barriers may be present that excludes a CWD from participating in the environment and how these barriers can be addressed so CWD can reach their potential.

Disability Justice

Viewed through the social model lens of CDT and the underlying aspects of diversity, inclusion, and equity, is the ability to recognise places and spaces where change can and needs to be made. These places and spaces of change can be understood to be what Piepzna-Samarasinha (2018) describes as **disability justice**, where society is called upon to change attitudes and environments yet does not recognise or is not willing to recognise when this can be done. Using an insider/outsider lens, the eight vignettes presented highlight some of the everyday challenges faced by Taylor's navigation of education settings and social interactions – places and spaces – and the complex ways they both reinforce and sometimes challenge the normative assumptions previously mentioned.

A Question of Perspective

There are a range of positions to be considered when researching people with a disability, one tension being the authenticity of the researcher's voice and the question of who has the right to speak for whom? It has been argued, for example, that in order to create authenticity, disability research needs to consider both the insider (lived experience) and the outsider (non-lived experience) perspective (Barnes & Mercer, 2010; Erevelles, 2011; Goodley et al., 2012; Shakespeare, 2014), recognising that each position has a contribution to make.

This difference in perspective brings to light one's own understanding of a moment in time and can be understood to have a centrality of truth dependent on the lens through

which it is viewed. The outsider position, for example, can have advantages, as this perspective permits observations and conclusions to be made about what is happening that an insider may be unable to see, because outsiders limited understanding does not imply they cannot develop an understanding or insight (Mohler & Rudman, 2022). This difference might then be ‘an opportunity for the co-construction of new insights’ (Blix, 2015, p. 182). On the other hand, there also exists an argument that outsiders, for example, are ‘unable to understand, or accurately represent the experiences of the insider perspective’ (Hayfield & Huxley, 2015, p. 5).

The issue of position is especially important when research is undertaken with marginalised groups such as disability (Bhopal & Deuchar, 2015). What is argued is power relations, subjectivity, objectivity, integrity and transparency need to be foregrounded, as there is the danger that the researcher may impose an essentialist view on the people they are researching (Bhopal & Deuchar, 2015). This essentialist view can then reinforce and perpetuate stereotypes rather than challenging them, making the non-disabled researcher as one who holds the specialised knowledge and skills without deeply understanding the insider perspective (Inckle et al., 2023). Therefore, it is incumbent that outsider research be ethical, enhances the lives of the insider, and is sensitive to the perspectives of those being researched (Hayfield & Huxley, 2015). One way to achieve this sensitivity is through using a retrospective autoethnographic lens that provides insight into these perspectives (Sparkes, 2024).

Autoethnography

Autoethnography provides a powerful way to explore the issue of societal attitude towards disability because it gives voice to personal experience (Denzin, 2014). It is important to note, however, that one’s perception of the experiences and their significance are rooted in what meaning these experiences are given, and the ways these meanings relate to a sense of self and the emotions they evoke (Custer, 2014). Autoethnographic research, argues Ellis et al. (2011), is both a ‘process and a product’ (p. 273) and privileges the researcher as the source of knowledge.

However, we also note that the use of the self to learn about the other through the sharing of the same experiences offers a unique perspective. Therefore, this perspective is not just about ‘knowing the world’ but also about ‘being in the world’ (Jones et al., 2013, p. 10), and the associated rich opportunity to interpret, reinterpret and revisit lived experiences, a position we share in relation to Taylor and PWD.

Although autoethnography as a well-established methodology can provide important personal insights regarding the phenomena being researched, there also exist critics who claim that autoethnography has disadvantages and limitations due to its lack of authenticity, validity, and subjectivity (Besio, 2019; E. Campbell, 2017). Whereas traditional research methods seek to answer questions related to the phenomena being studied from an outsider perspective, autoethnography provides the researcher the opportunity to look at the phenomena from a personal, insider perspective (Kasnitz, 2020). Using autoethnography as a research method provides an important opportunity for critical analysis of the context being studied from a personal perspective, and as a research method, can be ‘artistically constructed pieces of “text” (emphasis in the original) that evoke the imagination and increase the reader’s understanding’ (Muncey, 2010, p. 8).

It is also important to note that while Taylor – the focus of this paper – is one individual, these experiences are representative of many issues people with a disability face. Taylor, for example, warrants inclusion and being valued for who they are that is consistent with people everywhere, people with a disability like Taylor desire agency, however the issues they often face means that agency is denied them (Terzi, 2020). This denial, especially with children, is not because people with a disability are incapable of making choices themselves, but simply because their ability to make choices goes unrecognised (Holler & Werner, 2022). We now consider diversity, inclusion, and equity, and how these manifest in Taylor's life in turn.

Diversity

Referencing our discussion on the role of language and the meanings that are attributed to key concepts, we describe diversity as encompassing all similarities and differences of individuals, including personality, identity, and provision. Diversity as an organising idea can constitute both personal advantages and disadvantages (Terzi, 2020), and this comparison is often based in the concept of what is commonly understood to be a normal functioning in society. Diversity, rather than being seen as an inclusive term, can be seen as a departure from normality (Terzi, 2020), resulting in a lack of privacy and dehumanising status.

The following vignette is an example of how an everyday social outing where Taylor was treated in this way.

Taylor and I had gone to see some sand sculptures at a local event. I noticed a woman in her 50's, staring at Taylor for quite a long time, and then proceeded to take a photo. On approach when I asked why she had taken the photo, the woman stated she had never seen a child in that type of wheelchair before (it was one specially made for Taylor as a toddler) and wanted to show her friends. When further questioned about the photo, as she may have had a genuine reason for taking it, her reply was that she thought it was 'cute'! I spoke to her about how inappropriate it was to take the photo without seeking permission and that Taylor was not a spectacle to be photographed and shown around. I asked her to delete the photo, which she reluctantly did.

This interaction reveals an example of a societal attitude towards diversity, especially PWD. Key to this issue is the way this attitude disables people with a disability more than the disability itself. The question explored here is why did the woman feel it was appropriate to take a photo of Taylor? Illustrating this point, Pearson, in the documentary *The Ugly Face of Hate Crime* (2015) notes that, 'by having a disability, you lose anonymity, and become public property to be stared at, ridiculed and touched, with no thought of who you are and your rights' (Binyon, 2015, pp. 25,37–25,48), an issue reflected here.

These attitudes, as noted here, represent an aspect of ableism based on the premise that impairment (irrespective of type) is inherently negative (Bogart & Dunn, 2019; F. Campbell, 2009; Nario-Redmond, 2020). In this attitude, PWD are seen as being "invalid" (adjective) as they do not fit the notion of what it is to be fully human (F. Campbell, 2009), and therefore have no 'right' to privacy. This impoverished form of thinking shapes the world of disability with issues of diversity and equity producing attitudes of discrimination, privileging a non-disabled perspective over a disabled perspective.

However, an enactment of diversity can be about seeing places and spaces where changes need to and can be made. Recognising and enacting these changes is an educational process within itself, with these commensurate changes leading to a more just and inclusive society. The following is one of Taylor's experiences that occurred in a school setting.

In Taylor's first year at school, the teacher decided to measure each child's height at the beginning of the school year and a final measurement at the end of the year, so parents could see how much their child had grown, not just in knowledge but also in height. As Taylor was in a wheelchair, thus height would not change, and wanting to include Taylor in this experience, posed a challenge for the teacher. The teacher measured Taylor's height at the beginning of the year, sitting in the chair at the lowest height, [Taylor's chair goes up and down to different heights], then at the end of the year measured all the children both standing flat and also on their tiptoes. The teacher then measured Taylor's wheelchair at its maximum height, calling this its Tippy wheels alongside the children's tippy toe height and recorded this on the classroom wall for everyone to see.

This vignette reveals an example of how disability justice enacted through inclusion can be achieved in a classroom when a teacher is able to see places and spaces where adaption can be made to include diversity as part of everyday practice. Inclusive classroom settings, as described here, are premised on the belief that all children have the right to participate in and have opportunities to learn and belong with their typically developing peers (Horn et al., 2016).

Inclusion

Inclusion is the practice of providing equal access, opportunities, and resources for those who are marginalised, such as people with a disability and requires society to see places and spaces where changes need to and can be made (Goodley et al., 2012, 2018; Shakespeare, 2013). Recognising and enacting these changes is an education within itself, with these commensurate changes leading to a more just and inclusive society where disability is just one aspect of personhood.

The following vignette illustrates how society can see disability as 'other', or as not belonging to society, which is often enacted daily for PWD, and thus not worthy of being included as part of everyday society.

Having noticed the popular trend to place family decals on the rear window of cars, I had decided to purchase some for Taylor's family to place on their car. When I approached a local gift shop, I observed there were no decals that depicted a child in a wheelchair on the display. I asked the shop assistant if these were available and she replied, 'yes' and then promptly lent down a grabbed some from under the counter. When I asked her why they were kept there and not on display she replied, 'we don't like to display them with the others' when asked why, she stated that they don't get asked for them a lot, so keep them under the counter. I then added, maybe if they were on display with the others, they might sell more, at this she shrugged her shoulders, and after I had purchased what I needed, she returned them under the counter.

It is prudent to note that the shop assistant may not have been in position to reposition these decals without approval, however the issue is not about approval, but rather that these representations of disability not being visible in the first place. The action of

othering Taylor, that is being treated as an object rather than a person with rights, is based upon stereotyping and dehumanising those who do not fit into the 'us-ness' of society (Sitruk et al., 2023). This social construction of Taylor as other fits within the paradigm of disablism and is part of PWD's reality, as not being part of the group, and 'different in some fundamental way' (Matthews, 2023, p. 8).

Unsurprisingly, the concept of othering is well documented in disability literature and highlights the importance of understanding how society constructs disability (Mik-Meyer, 2016). For many PWD's social participation can be restricted due to society's perception and understanding of disability and how those with a disability should be (Erevelles, 2011). Disability researchers such as Shakespeare (2013) and Withers (2012) argue that discrimination exists not because people with disabilities have needs different from their non-disabled peers, but because of the social conditions that permits division and exclusion from society (the social model previously described).

The United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with a Disability (2007), outline aspects of the law against discrimination of PWD, however the relationship between this act and societal attitudes/discrimination is complex. The lack of awareness, as to what constitutes access for people with disabilities is concerning and the impact of social barriers and discriminatory practices, are not obvious until they are called out, and PWD are 'routinely offered a lesser quality service' and seen as being 'better than nothing' (Wertans & Burch, 2022, p. 57).

To enact the key principles of diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility, PWD need to be on an equal basis as non-disabled persons. The time and effort taken to access services, for example, should not be longer or more difficult than for people without a disability.

Restrictive Thinking

The following vignette provides an insight into restrictive thinking, safety and wellbeing, where a business believes they are being inclusive; however, by their very actions reinforce that provision for PWD is not an important issue and access is not always on an equal basis with the non-disabled. This lack of provision can not only impact PWD, their sense of wellbeing and security, but also an impact on their family, carers, and friends.

I accompanied Taylor to a live musical performed in an old theatre, located on the second floor without immediate access for PWD. Access was via a lift in a café alongside the theatre which was also used to ferry the café's rubbish to the basement. The lift was very small and had overflowing rubbish bins in it, meaning that only Taylor and the lift operator could fit into the lift. Taylor was quite distressed at being in the lift alone with a stranger. I gave a reassurance that I would be at the top when the lift opened, meaning I had to run through the café, and up the two flights of stairs so I could honour my promise.

These lived experiences highlight inclusion, access, equity, and safety issues embedded in the lives of many PWD. This scenario is not unique and raises a series of concerns about why the rubbish bins were not removed, why was it considered appropriate to have a child enter a lift with an unknown adult, the lack of universal design planning (Imrie, 2012) and respect for those who require the lift to access the theatre? Not only does this incident raise issues about accessibility, but this also highlights the vulnerability of people with physical disabilities and more importantly, the vulnerability of children with

disabilities and those around them. Insecurity and vulnerability are a major concern for parents, families and carers of children with disabilities, and parents make considerable efforts to protect their child/ren from potential harm (Andresen, 2014). In this instance, this protection was taken away from Taylor, and that Taylor's safety and well-being was not being compromised had to be assumed.

Access

Significantly, equal access to buildings and transport is an ongoing issue for PWD despite Universal Design requirements being a fundamental part of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (Article 9:2 a & b). Often these design requirements are not fully embedded in contemporary building policies, built environments and transportation systems. There are however spaces and places where building designers have considered the tenets of Universal Design that require 'environments, programs and services to be usable by all people to the greatest extent possible' (Fiske, 2021, universal design charter section, para 1) as shown in the following vignette.

Taylor is fascinated with sea creatures, and enjoys visiting the local aquarium, because it has been designed with inclusion of all children in mind. The building has both ramps and elevators that connect all levels, and the exhibits are at various heights allowing Taylor to see, feel and participate in all aspects of the exhibits. On one visit Taylor had asked to watch the seal show, and at the scheduled time we went to the presentation area. Upon arrival, the staff asked Taylor if 'they' would be comfortable sitting at the front with the other children or wanted to stay at the back with me. The area at the front had been designed especially for wheelchairs, was used regularly for school groups, and did not obscure the view of those sitting behind. Taylor chose to go down the front with a staff member to the specially designed area. At the completion of the show the same staff member brought Taylor back up the ramp to where I had been watching the show.

This vignette demonstrates how implementing the tenets of Universal Design, places and spaces, when properly designed, function for everyone (Null, 2014). However, although Universal Design is a common-sense strategy for providing environments for everyone, accessibility for PWD often remains a fringe consideration (Hamraire, 2016). This understanding suggests an awareness that all PWD have the right to access products and environments the same as non-disabled people. However, the challenge is how to translate these principles into practice, and to recognise, respond to, and realise the universal objectives relating to access and equity and **disability justice** for everyone (Imrie, 2012).

Equity

Equity, as described by McKay and Taket (2020), relates to social justice and fairness and is value based and is often interpreted differently – a question of perspective as we have argued. Furthermore, equity is strongly connected to human rights principles that encompasses everyone, regardless of their sex, race, belief system or ability. Despite this principle PWD often find themselves void of these rights, especially when it comes to access to buildings, social gatherings, and education. Participation restrictions are a consequence of 'society's inability to accommodate

diversity' (Watson et al., 2020, p. 117) rather than the disability itself and has physical, social and educational implications. The following vignette is an example of where Taylor's disability impacted access and consequently was denied equity and disability justice.

As part of the school curriculum the teachers had decided to take the children to the local beach to explore the sand and seek out 'found' sea items and then return with these to the classroom to use further in their learning. This, however, posed a problem in relation to Taylor and having access to suitable transport and the beach. To this end the school sent a letter home asking Taylor's parents not to send Taylor to school on this day so the children could go to the beach, and they would not have to organise for Taylor to stay back at the school with another class. Upon hearing this, I organised time away from my paid employment to take Taylor to the excursion in the family car. I also hired a beach suitable wheelchair so they could participate in this experience with their classmates.

This example highlights how disability is often constructed and impacts on the participation of PWD. Here, **disability injustice** has occurred through a lack of planning and equity for Taylor's inclusion. Frustratingly, the responsibility fell to others to find an equitable solution.

In responding appropriately to inequality and **disability justice**, or in this case **injustice**, educational settings cannot exclude experiences valuable for PWD to 'do, be, achieve or enjoy' (Barclay, 2018, p. 63), such as described in the preceding vignette. The school's response in this instance highlights the concern of both educational settings and society to find places and spaces where PWD experience equity and **disability justice**.

The concept of inclusion and inclusive practices is the underlying interactional factor in this example and frames many difficulties PWD face in a disabling environment (Conn, 2014) even though these actions go against the Australian Disability Discrimination Act (1992) [Division 2: 22:2,2A.23]. These examples challenge designers of spaces and educators to rethink their ideas relating to the creation of places and spaces that foster fair and equitable inclusion. In educational settings, this involves curriculum and social learning opportunities that promote an 'inclusive sense of community for all children in their classroom' (Genishi & Goodwin, 2008, p. 174). The following vignette is an example of how this can be manifested in schools.

Every year Taylor's school has an obstacle course as part of school fundraising efforts. The physical education teacher realised that the usual course with climbing and crawling would not allow Taylor to participate equitably. To remedy this the obstacle course was reorganised with ramps and covered arches so Taylor could participate on an equitable basis with their non-disabled peers.

In considering the role of formal education embodied through the school, for example, it is clear that 'the attitudes of the management and teachers play a crucial role' (Grober & Wessels, 2020, p. 246) in successful inclusion in school settings.

However, it is often the case that equity, social justice, and fairness are expressed as a 'social problem' (Rimmerman, 2014, p. 40), and navigating the impact is part of the daily reality for many PWD bringing up feelings of sadness, unworthiness, shame, anxiety, and fear of being stigmatised. This feeling of apartness, is premised on the belief that to have a disability is to be inferior, different, and excluded from aspects of mainstream society (Barnes & Mercer, 2010), and consequently the fear of being stigmatised can lead to

avoidance of potentially distressing situations as the focus becomes the individual's functionality in the situation. This perception of functionality influences the way PWD position themselves in society compared to non-disabled people (Richard & Hennekam, 2021).

A Matter of Agency

Functionality, in this context, often manifests itself through interability communication and is often 'occupied by a third speaker' (Williams & Porter, 2015, p. 72), and foregrounds PWD's competence to speak for themselves. In research, this is often referred to as third-party speak (Williams, 2011; Williams & Porter, 2015). Third-party speak is premised upon the belief that if you have a disability, you are not able to think or act for yourself, and therefore any questions relating to the needs of the person with a disability should be directed at the 'able-bodied' person accompanying them (Williams & Porter, 2015), reflected in the following vignette.

As a family we visited the local zoological gardens and could move around the environment with ease, as generally, the zoo is accessible for parents with strollers and consequently wheelchairs. We visited many exhibits and Taylor was able to see as there were viewing windows at various heights. When we came to the tiger exhibit there was a large crowd of people, so we waited at the back until the crowd had dissipated then made our way toward the viewing area. However, we were still somewhat at the back of people. Consequently, one gentleman turned around and saw Taylor, looked at me and asked, 'Do I need to move so they can see?' My response was, 'I am not sure, why don't you ask?' He seemed taken aback but responded, 'Oh sorry', and proceeded to ask Taylor if he needed to move.

This attitude sees disability as an interaction that connects the perception of typical functioning of disability and societal belief of what it means to have a disability. This divergence of attitude is based on a 'widely shared assumption that disabilities reduce quality of life' and appear 'embedded deep in the history of western philosophy' (Wasserman et al., 2016, p. 22). As a consequence, people with disability are seen as not having the capacity to make informed decisions that impact their lives (Wasserman et al., 2016; Watson, 2016). So, although equity is about giving everyone similar opportunities to participate, sometimes the reality is less than ideal, therefore it is incumbent on society and education settings to lessen this gap by recognising and addressing the needs of CWD (Gonski, 2011).

Conclusion

The goal of this paper has been to contribute to the understanding of places and spaces where **disability justice** can be revealed through the challenges faced by Taylor, a young child with a disability, exemplified from a carer perspective. We note that learning sits at the intersection of people, place and context and it is at that this intersection that education, both for the individual and society, is contingent on engagement and participation. In this respect, places and spaces can be thought as sites where disability justice can be enacted, it is this enactment that is key, and behaviours and actions grow attitudes and beliefs. In describing Taylor's experiences, we highlight a number of these and what these might mean.

We note that the exemplars provided present only one 'truth' and do not presume to claim this is Taylor's 'truth'. However, the use of authentic lived experiences helps provide context and consideration of the challenges that PWD face and shows the vulnerability of PWD as they engage in everyday society.

In terms of markers of quality, the question of reliability and rigour is a concern voiced by many in academia, due to the possibility that the results may be impacted by the closeness of the researcher to the research subject (Creswell & Poth, 2018; Mendez, 2013). This issue can be addressed by applying four criteria, as developed by seminal writers Guba and Lincoln (1985) in relation to 'the trustworthiness of research as; credibility, transferability, dependability and confirmability' (Le Roux, 2015, p. 3). This study addressed these through member checking, rich description, peer debriefing and reflexivity (Johnson et al., 2020).

As this research is unique to Taylor and their carer, transferability maybe called into question. As reliability of research refers to the extent that the findings can be replicated and 'is based on the assumption that there is a single reality' (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016, p. 250), and that repeating this will lead to the same results. In autoethnographic studies 'replication is not practical, and an alternate interpretation may not validate the conclusions of the study' (Eitzel, 2023, p. 4). Autoethnographic studies are therefore unique in their application and are now considered a valuable methodology in the social sciences in the way it offers another perspective on the issue being researched through insider/outsider knowledge (Hughes et al., 2012; Le Roux, 2015; Mendez, 2013).

Finally, the personal accounts of these challenges recounted have been juxtaposed with various concepts relating to the social model of disability within a CDT framework. These vignettes were interrogated using the notions of **diversity, inclusion, and equity**. What is argued from a personal and lived experience of someone caring for a child with a disability, is that many non-disabled persons and policymakers implicitly or explicitly adopt misunderstandings of disability. Consequently, education through places and spaces are key to a more just society.

This study has been approved by the Murdoch University Human Research Ethics Committee (Approval 2021/155). If you have any reservation or complaint about the ethical conduct of this research, and wish to talk with an independent person, you may contact Murdoch University's Research Ethics & Integrity on Tel. 08 9360 6677 (+61 8 9360 6677 for overseas studies) or e-mail julie.carmel@murdoch.edu.au. Any issues you raise will be treated in confidence and investigated fully, and you will be informed of the outcome.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

ORCID

Julie- Mary Carmel  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-2328-9356>

Sian Chapman  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-7474-0277>

Peter Wright  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-6433-3889>

References

- Andresen, S. (2014). Childhood vulnerability: Systematic, structural, and individual dimensions. *Child Indicators Research*, 7(4), 699–713. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12187-014-9248-4>
- Barclay, L. (2018). *Disability with dignity: justice, human rights and equal status* (1st ed. Vol. 12). Taylor and Francis Group. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781351017114>
- Barnes, C., & Mercer, G. (2010). *Exploring disability* (2nd ed.). Polity Press.
- Besio, K. (2019). Autoethnography. In A. Kobayashi (Ed.), *International encyclopedia of human geography* (2nd ed., Vol. 1, pp. 243–247). Elsevier. <https://doi.org/10.106/B978-0-08-102295-5-10160-x>
- Bhopal, K., & Deuchar, R. (Eds.). (2015). *Researching marginalized groups* (1st ed.). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315740782>
- Binyon, S. (2015). *The ugly face of disability hate crime*. A. Pearson; BBC Network. <https://www.imdb.com/title/tt5857682/>
- Blix, B. H. (2015). Something decent to wear: Performances of being an insider and an outsider in indigenous research. *Qualitative Inquiry*, 21(2), 175–183. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1077800414542702>
- Bogart, K., & Dunn, D. (2019). Ableism: Special issue introduction. *The Journal of Social Issues*, 75(3), 650–664. <https://doi.org/10.1111/josi.12354>
- Campbell, E. (2017). Apparently being a self-obsessed c**t is now academically lauded": Experiencing Twitter trolling of autoethnographers. *Forum: Qualitative Social Research*, 18(3), 2819. <https://doi.org/10.17169/fqs-18.3.2819>
- Campbell, F. (2009). *Contours of ableism, the production of disability and abledness*. Palgrave Macmillan. <https://doi.org/10.1057/9780230245181>
- Campbell, S. M., & Stramondo, J. (2023). Expressed ableism. *Ergo*, 9(60), 1627–1658. <https://doi.org/10.3998/ergo.3585>
- Conn, C. (2014). *Autism and the social world of childhood: A sociocultural perspective on theory and practice*. Routledge.
- Creswell, J., & Poth, C. (2018). *Qualitative inquiry & research design: Choosing among five approaches* (4th ed.). Sage.
- Cuba, E. G., & Lincoln, Y. S. (1985). *Naturalistic enquiry* (vol.75). Sage.
- Custer, D. (2014). Autoethnography as a transformative research method. *The Qualitative Report*, 19(37), 1–13. <https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2014.1011>
- Denzin, N. K. (Ed.). (2014). *Interpretive autoethnography* (2nd ed.). Sage.
- Dixon, K., Braye, S., & Gibbons, T. (2022). Still outsiders: The inclusion of disabled children and young people in physical education in England. *Disability & Society*, 37(10), 1549–1567. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09687599.2021.1907551>
- Dunn, D. S. (2019). Outsider privileges can lead to insider disadvantages: Some psychosocial aspects of ableism. *The Journal of Social Issues*, 75(3), 665–682. <https://doi.org/10.1111/josi.12331>
- Eitzel, M. V. (2023). Autoethnographic assessment of a manifesto for more trustworthy, relevant, and just models. *Environmental Modelling & Software*, 164(105690), 105690. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.envsoft.2023.105690>
- Ellis, C., Adams, T., & Bolcher, A. (2011). Autoethnography: An overview. *Historical Social Research*, 36(4), 273–290. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23032294>
- Erevelles, N. (2011). *Disability and difference in global contexts: Enabling a transformative body politic*. Palgrave Macmillan.
- Fiske, R. (2021). *Universal design policy* [Report]. <https://www.vhba.vic.gov.au/universal-design-policy>
- Genishi, C., & Goodwin, A. (2008). *Diversities in early childhood education: Rethinking and doing*. Routledge.
- Gonski, D. (2011). *Improving educational equity in Australia*. https://www.gie.unsw.edu.au/sites/default/files/documents/Gonski%20Equity%20Paper_web_2.pdf
- Goodley, D., Hughes, B., & Davis, L. (Eds.). (2012). *Disability and social theory*. Palgrave Macmillan. <https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137023001>

- Goodley, D., Liddiard, K., & Runswick-Cole, K. (2018). Feeling disability: Theories of affect and critical disability studies. *Disability & Society*, 33(2), 197–217. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09687599.2017.1402752>
- Grober, H., & Wessels, S. (2020). Hear their voices: Selfconfiguration experiences of learners with mild learning difficulties within the learner-teacher relationship. *International Journal of Disability, Development and Education*, 67(3), 243–262. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1034912X.2018.1499878>
- Hall, M. (2019). Critical disability theory. In E. N. Zalta (Ed.), *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. <https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2019/entries/disability-critical/> (Winter ed).
- Hamraire, A. (2016). Universal design and the problem of post-disability ideology. *Design and Culture: The Journal of the Design Forum*, 8(3), 285–309. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17547075.2016.1218714>
- Hayfield, N., & Huxley, C. (2015). Insider and outsider perspectives: Reflections on research identities in research with lesbian and bisexual women. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 12(2), 91–106. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14780887.2014.918224>
- Holler, R., & Werner, S. (2022). Necessity is neither condemned nor praised': Social workers' meanings of guardianship for disabled people. *British Journal of Social Work*, 52(1), 98–115. <https://doi.org/10.1093/bjsw/bcaa208>
- Horn, E. M., Palmer, S. B., Butera, G. D., & Lieber, J. A. (2016). *Six steps to inclusive preschool curriculum*. Brookes Publishing Co.
- Hughes, S., Pennington, J. L., & Makis, S. (2012). Translating autoethnography across the AERA standards: Toward understanding autoethnographic scholarship as empirical research. *Educational Reseracher*, 41(6), 209–219. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0013189X12442983>
- Imrie, R. (2012). Universalism, universal design and equitable access to the built environment. *Disability and Rehabilitation*, 34(10), 873–882. <https://doi.org/10.3109/09638288.2011.624250>
- Inckle, K., Brighton, J., & Sparkes, A. (2023). Who is "us" in "nothing about Us without US"? Rethinking the politics of disability research. *Disability Studies Quarterly*, 42(3–4). <https://doi.org/10.18061/dsq.v42i3-4.7947>
- Johnson, J., Adkins, D., & Chauvin, S. (2020). A review of quality indicators of rigor in qualitative research. *American Journal of Pharmaceutical Education*, 84(1), 138–146. <https://doi.org/10.5688/ajpe7120>
- Jones, S., Adams, T., & Ellis, C. (Eds.). (2013). *Handbook of autoethnography*. Left Coast Press. Inc.
- Kasnitz, D. (2020). The politics of disability performativity: An autoethnography. *Current Anthropology*, 61(S21), S16–S25. <https://doi.org/10.1086/705782>
- Le Roux, C. (2015). *An autoethnographic appraisal of autoethnography as a research method* (Split. Bulgaria).
- Matthews, P. (2023). *Other-person-ness and the person with profound disabilities*. Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003286844>
- McKay, F., & Taket, A. (2020). *Health equity, social justice and human rights* (2nd ed.). Routledge.
- Meekosha, H., & Shuttleworth, R. (2017). What's so 'critical' about critical disability studies? *Australian Journal of Human Rights*, 15(1), 47–75. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1323238X.2009.11910861>
- Mendez, M. (2013). Autoethnography as a research method: Advantages, limitations and criticisms. *Columbian Applied Linguistics Journal*, 15(2), 279–287. <https://doi.org/10.14483/udistrital.jour.calj.2013.2.a09>
- Merriam, S. B., & Tisdell, E. J. (2016). *Qualitative research: A guide to design and implementation* (4th ed. Jossey-Bass.).
- Mik-Meyer, N. (2016). Othering, ablesim and disability: A discursive analysis of co-workers' construction of colleagues with visible impairments. *Human Relations*, 69(6), 1341–1363. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0018726715618454>
- Mohler, E. C., & Rudman, D. L. (2022). Negotiating the insider/outsider researcher position within qualitative disability studies research. *The Qualitative Report*, 27(6), 1511–1521. <https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2022.5047>
- Muncey, T. (2010). *Creating autoethnographies*. Sage Publications.
- Munn, F. (2017). Emergency care and NHS pay on RCN's congress agenda. *Nursing Standard*, 31(37), 7–8. <https://doi.org/10.7748/ns.31.37.7.s3>

- Nario-Redmond, M. (2020). *Ableism. The causes and consequences of disability prejudice*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Null, R. (2014). *Universal design. principles and models*. CRC Press. <https://doi.org/10.1201/b15580>
- Petasis, A. (2019). Discrepancies of the medical, social and biopsychosocial models of disability; a comprehensive theoretical framework. *The International Journal of Business Management and Technology*, 3(4 July), 2581–3889.
- Piepzna-Samarasinha, L. L. (2018). *Care work: Disability dreaming*. Arsena IPulp Press.
- Pothier, D., & Devlin, R. (2014). *Critical disability theory: Essays in philosophy, politics, policy and law*. UBC Press.
- Richard, S., & Hennekam, S. (2021). Constructing a positive identity as a disabled worker through social comparison: The role of stigma and disability characteristics. *Journal of Vocational Behavior*, 125, 103528. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jvb.2020.103528>
- Rimmerman, A. (2014). *Social inclusion of people with disabilities: National and international perspectives*. Cambridge University Press.
- Shakespeare, T. (2013). *Disability rights and wrongs revisited* (2nd ed.). Taylor Francis Group.
- Shakespeare, T. (2014). *Disability rights and wrongs* (2nd ed.). Routledge.
- Sitruk, Jason, Summers, K., & Llyod, E. P. (2023). Dehumanizing disability: Evidence for subtle and blatant dehumanization of people with physical disabilities. *Current Research in Ecological and Social Psychology*, 5(100162), 1–11. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cresp.2023.100162>
- Sparkes, A. (2024). Autoethnography as an ethically contested terrain: Some thinking points for consideration. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 24(1), 107–139. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14780887.2023.2293073>
- Sztobryn-Giercuskiewicz, J. (2017). Critical disability theory as a theoretical framework for disability studies. In J. Neidbalski, M. Raclaw & D. Zuchowska-Skiba (Eds.), *Oblicza niepełnosprawności w praktyce i teorii (Faces of disability in practice and theory)* (pp. 29–35). ReserachGate.
- Terzi, L. (2020). Educational justice for students with intellectual disabilities. In A. Cureton & D. Wasserman (Eds.), *The oxford handbook of philosophy and disability*. Oxford University Press. 542–558.
- Thomas, G., & Sakellariou, D. (2018). *Disability, normalcy, and the everyday* (1st ed.). Routledge.
- Wasserman, D., Asch, A., Blustein, J., & Putnam, D. (2016). *Disability: Health, well-being, and personal relationships*. The Stanford encyclopedia of Philosophy, Winter 2016 edition. (529–538). <https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2016/entries/disability-health/>
- Watson, J. (2016). Assumptions of decision-making capacity: The role supporter attitudes play in the realisation of article 12 for people with severe or profound intellectual disability. *Laws*, 5(1). <https://doi.org/10.3390/laws5010006>
- Watson, J., Anderson, K., Frawley, P., & Balandin, S. (2020). Human rights for people with disability. In F. McKay & A. Taket (Eds.), *Health equity, social justice and human rights* (2nd ed. pp. 116–124). Routledge.
- Wertans, E., & Burch, L. (2022). It's backdoor accessibility': Disabled students' navigation of university campus. *Journal of Disability Studies in Education*, 3(1), 57–78. <https://doi.org/10.1163/25888803-bja10013>
- Williams, V. (2011). *Disability discourse; analysing inclusive conversations with people with intellectual disabilities*. Wiley-Blackwell.
- Williams, V., & Porter, S. (2015). Third-party turns and shared knowledge: Supports and challenges to disabled people in social care and research settings. *Communication & Medicine*, 12(1), 71–83. <https://doi.org/10.1558/cam.v12i1.30178>
- Withers, A. (2012). *Disability politics and theory*. Fernwood.